# A BRIEF NOTE ON

# THE INDIAN PEACE KEEPING FORCE (IPKF)

THE VIOLENT SRI LANKAN CIVIL WAR SAW A SUDDEN INFLUX OF refugees into India. The Indian government, first under Indira Gandhi and then under Rajiv Gandhi, sympathized with the Tamil insurrection, owing to the strong support for the cause in Tamil Nadu. The state soon became a sanctuary for separatists and a channel for the LTTE to smuggle weapons to Sri Lanka. Sri Lanka chose to limit its intervention even when LTTE supremo Prabhakaran was arrested and then released in Tamil Nadu in 1982.

The first round of civil violence flared in 1983 when the killing of thirteen soldiers of the Sri Lanka Army sparked anti-Tamil pogroms—the Black July riots—in which approximately 3000 Tamils were killed.[1] With militant attacks on the rise, as well as political and ethnic turmoil, Rajiv Gandhi's government attempted to maintain cordial diplomatic relations and restrict all aid to Tamil militants.

In June 1987, the Sri Lankan army laid siege to Jaffna, leading to mass civilian casualties. Fearing the prospect of a backlash from its own Tamil population, India sent unarmed ships for humanitarian assistance, but the convoy was intercepted and sent back by the Sri Lankan navy. In July 1987, India airdropped food parcels into Jaffna. This triggered a round of negotiations, and the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord was signed by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and Sri Lankan President J.R. Jayawardene in 1987. The primary task of the IPKF was to disarm the LTTE and all other rebel groups that took to arms to champion its cause. The LTTE was resistant to the terms of the agreement,[2] which stated (a) the devolution of power to